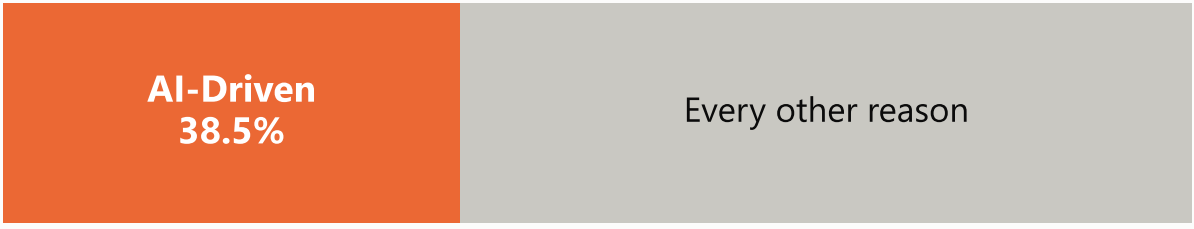
DATA STORY | OCTOBER 2026

Did AI really take the jobs?

I analysed 475 layoff announcements from 2026 (672,731 jobs, 421 companies, 13 industries) and checked them against official US labour data.



Share of 2026's announced job cuts

Hatim | Excel - Python - SQL - Power BI

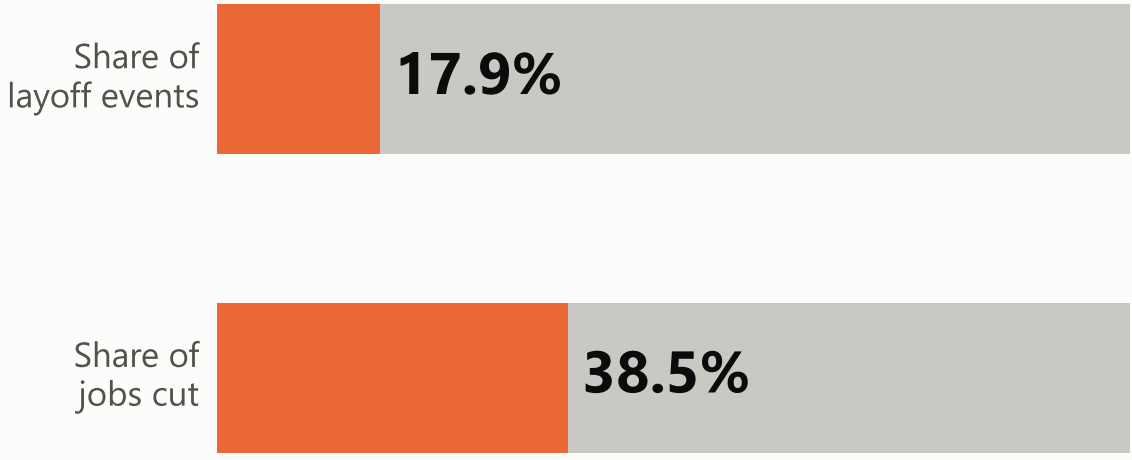
Swipe >

Data: layoffhedge.com 2026 Layoff Dataset (as of 6 Oct 2026); BLS JOLTS via FRED

INSIGHT 1

AI was named in 1 in 5 layoffs - but those took 2 in 5 jobs

AI-driven layoffs averaged 3,045 jobs each,
vs 1,061 for every other reason - about 3x bigger.



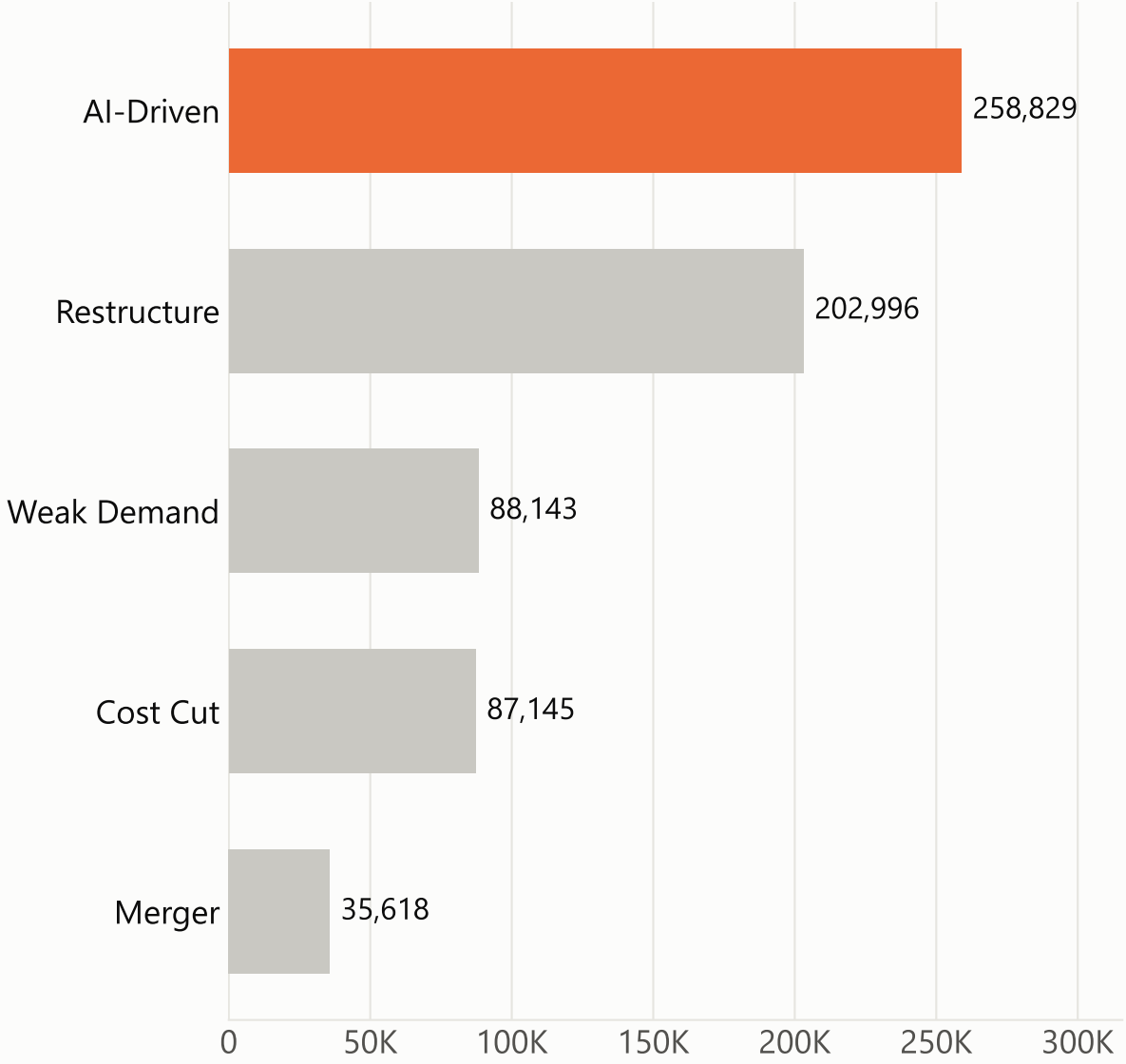
Orange = AI-Driven Grey = Restructure, Cost Cut, Weak Demand, Merger

Data: layoffhedge.com 2026 Layoff Dataset (as of 6 Oct 2026); BLS JOLTS via FRED

INSIGHT 2

AI is now the #1 stated reason for job cuts

Jobs cut in 2026 by the reason companies gave.
AI-Driven beat classic restructuring by 56K jobs.

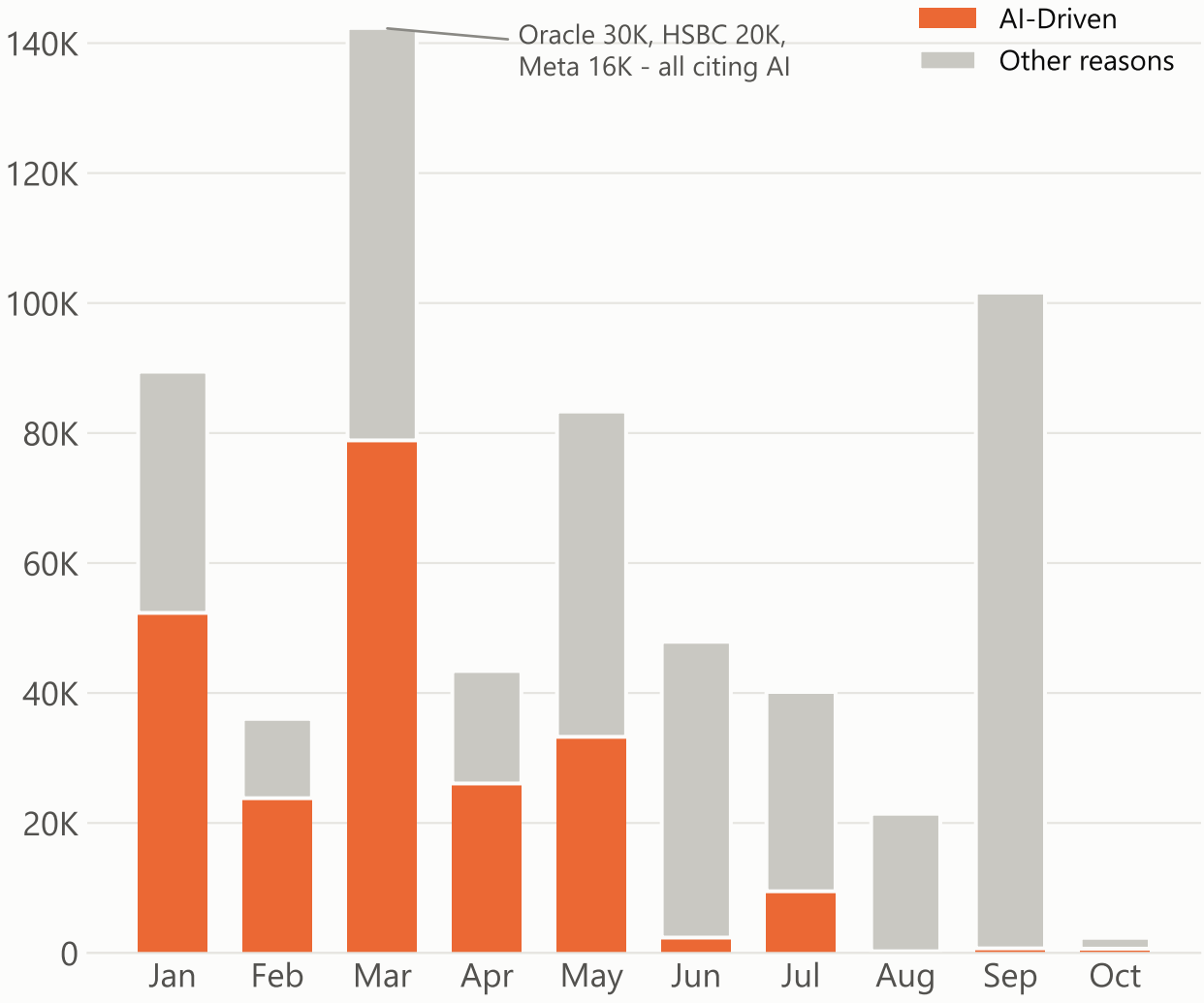


Data: layoffhedge.com 2026 Layoff Dataset (as of 6 Oct 2026); BLS JOLTS via FRED

INSIGHT 3

The 'AI layoff' wave was front-loaded into H1

AI-Driven share of jobs cut: 49% in Jan-Jun vs 6% in Jul-Sep.
Q3 cuts were mostly restructures, plant closures and WARN notices.



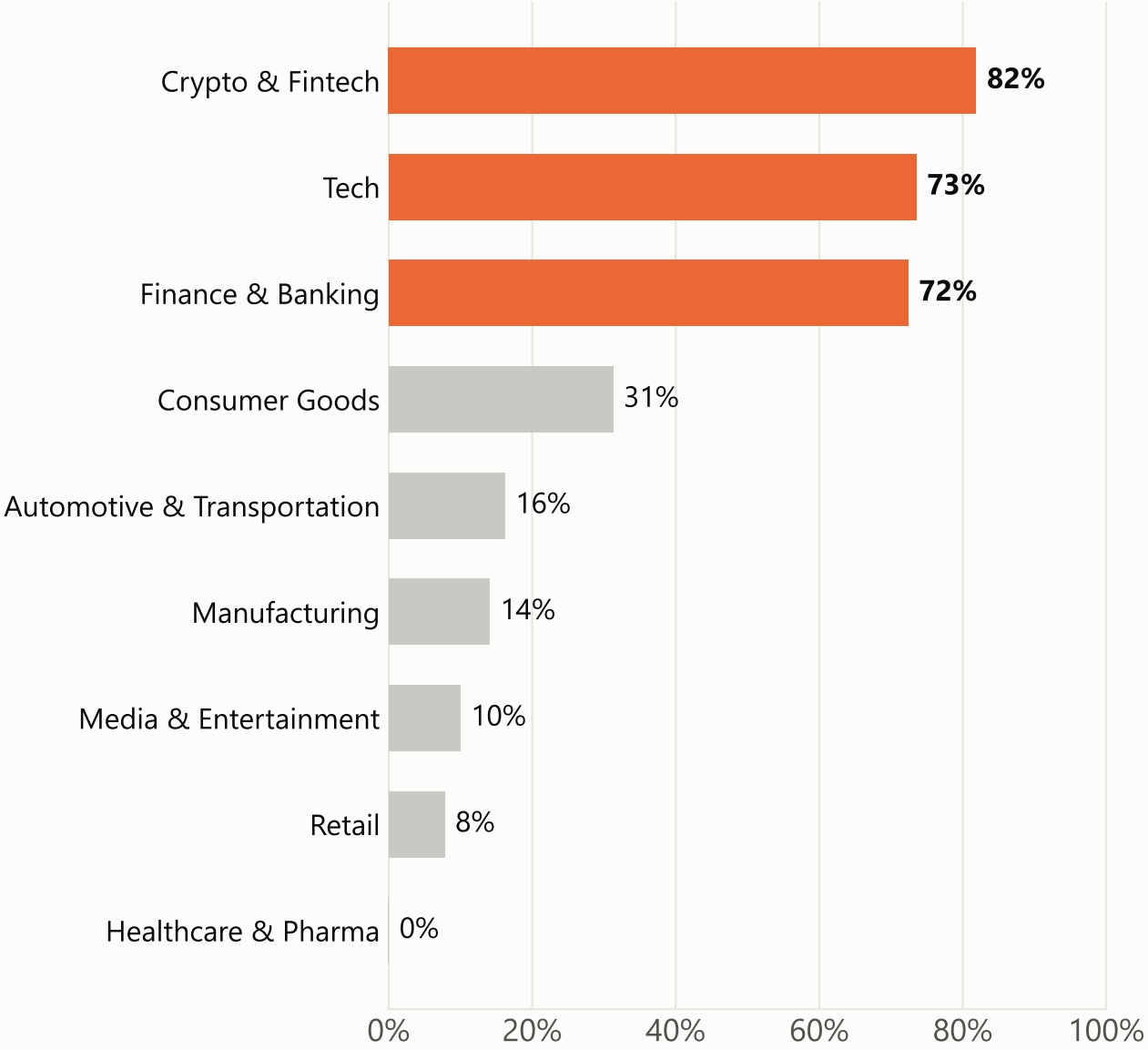
Oct 2026 is partial (to 6 Oct). Excludes 6 year-level / multi-year announcements.

Data: layoffhedge.com 2026 Layoff Dataset (as of 6 Oct 2026); BLS JOLTS via FRED

INSIGHT 4

Banks now blame AI almost as much as Big Tech does

Share of each industry's jobs cut that was AI-Driven (industries with 10+ layoff events).

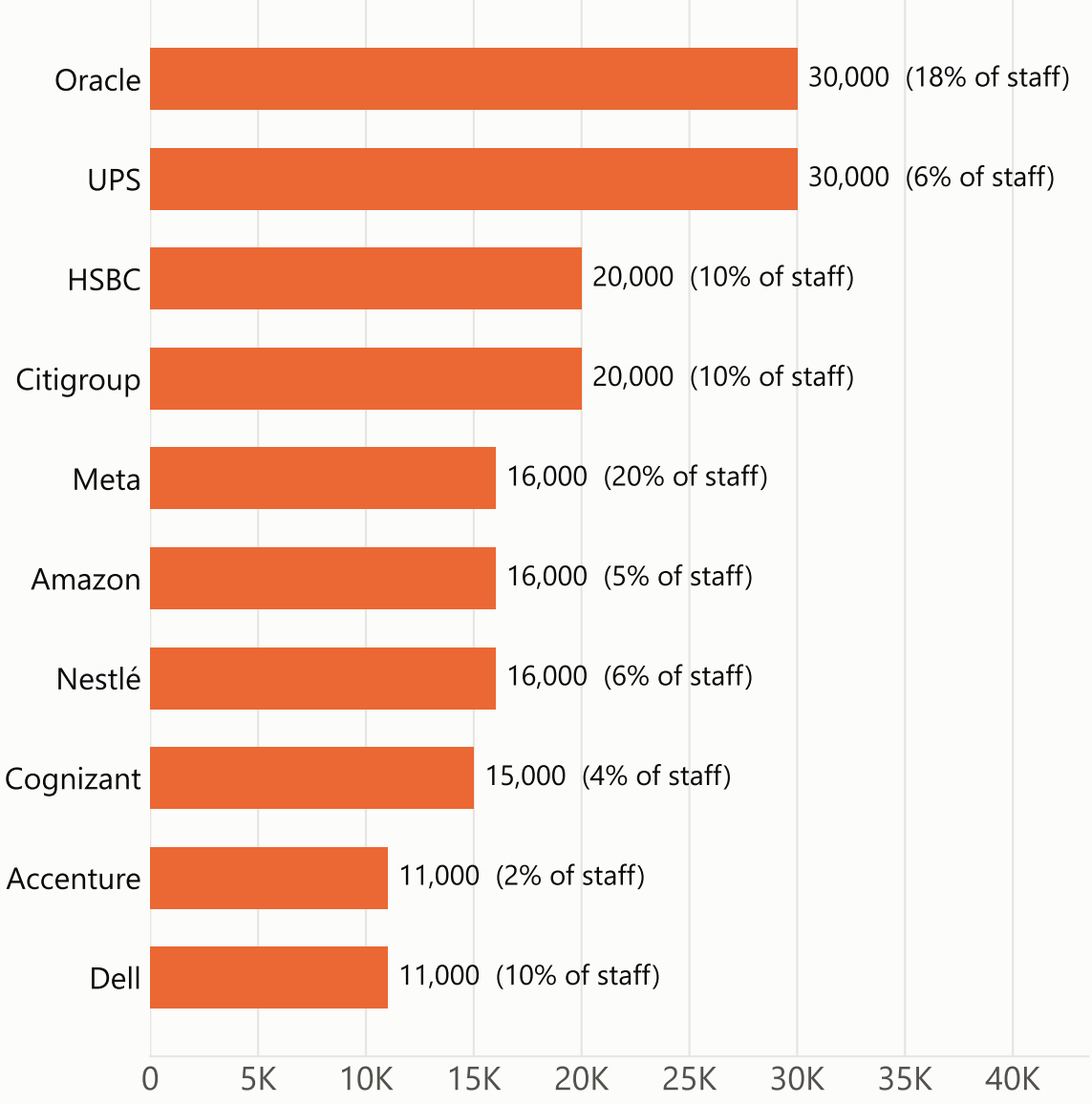


Data: layoffhedge.com 2026 Layoff Dataset (as of 6 Oct 2026); BLS JOLTS via FRED

INSIGHT 5

The 10 biggest AI-driven cuts of 2026

Jobs cut, and the share of each company's workforce.
Meta cut 1 in 5 employees.

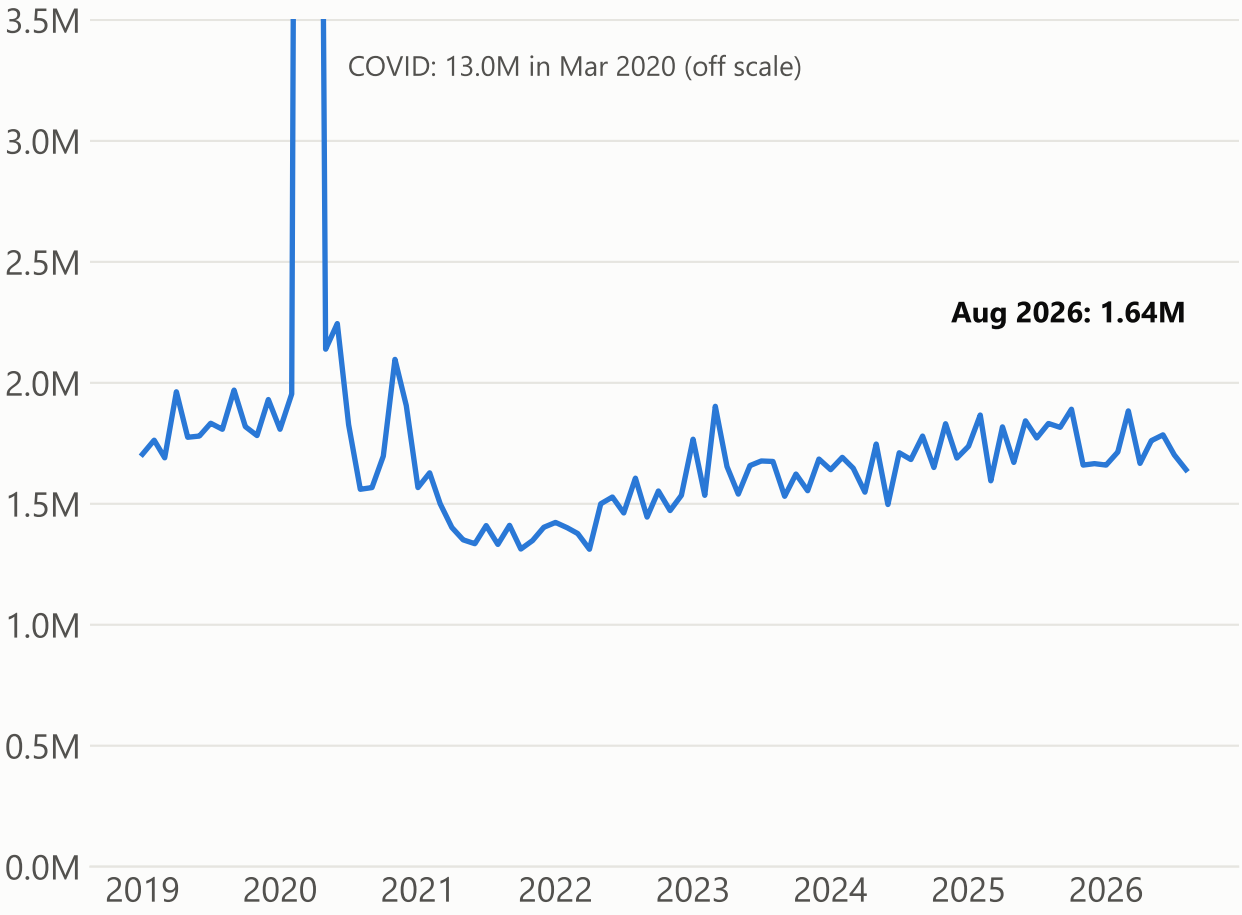


Data: layoffhedge.com 2026 Layoff Dataset (as of 6 Oct 2026); BLS JOLTS via FRED

REALITY CHECK

Zoom out: US layoffs are flat - not spiking

Official BLS data: US employers lay off ~1.7M people every month.
All AI-driven cuts announced worldwide in 2026 (259K)
= about 15% of ONE month of US layoffs.



US layoffs & discharges, total nonfarm, monthly, seasonally adjusted (BLS JOLTS, JTSLDL).
Layoff dataset is global; BLS is US-only - compared for scale, not like-for-like.

Data: layoffhedge.com 2026 Layoff Dataset (as of 6 Oct 2026); BLS JOLTS via FRED

SO, DID AI TAKE THE JOBS?

The headline is real. The wave is not (yet).

1 AI was the #1 stated reason for job cuts in 2026 (38.5% of jobs).

2 It's a big-company story: few announcements, huge numbers.

3 Tech, fintech and banking say 'AI' most. Autos and retail don't.

4 The AI share fell from 49% (H1) to 6% (Q3).

5 Official US layoff rates are flat vs 2024-25: 'AI' is a reason companies give, not yet a labour-market shock.

Built end-to-end: Python (clean) -> SQL (model + analysis) -> Excel (pivot & QA) -> Power BI (dashboard)

What surprised you most? Comment below.

Data: layoffhedge.com 2026 Layoff Dataset (as of 6 Oct 2026); BLS JOLTS via FRED